



NOT MUCH OF A REVOLUTION



CellFactor: Revolution is a long-awaited game that its developers insist is best played with a physics processing card, so we got ourselves an ASUS Ageia PhysX card. The game is totally free—but unless you own a PhysX card, you can only play a couple of missions. Find the game on this month's DVD.

CellFactor lets you choose from three different races—Black-op, Guardian, or Bishop (for any of the single-player campaigns or the multiplayer modes). Each of the races has special capabilities: for example, the Bishop can fly and throw things around, but has no weapons at all. There are a few special moves: the Guardian, for example, can

shoot off a couple of hundred feet and then shoot from up there while falling down. He also has two different weapons in each hand. There are a couple of vehicles and mechanical warriors to move you around the maps. While the buggy may be some fun, the mech warrior is way too slow to reach the action before it ends.

Alas, the game has no storyline whatsoever. It's a line-up of single skirmish missions on different maps against AI bots. Each level you win, another is unlocked—almost always as disappointing as the previous.

Some levels, however, are better looking and more fun, especially the more open ones. The indoor maps are cramped with too many objects trying to

take advantage of the PPU. This excess of objects gets in the way while you're going through the maps. You end up pushing away all sorts of debris and barrels. There are just five levels, so expect to be bored out of your mind real soon... To add to the disappointment, you only get four guns!

The use of physics in the game is the core strength of *CellFactor*. The game engine along the physics processing card allows huge numbers of objects of all sizes and shapes to react with each other like in real life, in real-time. But in-game, you have huge, heavy, metal objects floating around and bouncing off walls like gas balls, which is just plain silly.

It's a letdown when the game has the ability to do so much but it's all done so badly. You can use your powers to levitate objects and hurl them around the place—and at enemies. The interaction between the large numbers of objects is sort of interesting to see, but nothing special—*Half-Life 2* had it with the gravity gun, too. Here, the novelty fades away rather quickly.

The game supports HDR and per-pixel motion blurring, which gives it the look of a modern game. The models and textures aren't too detailed, and the levels are tasteless and lack identity. They're filled with neatly-stacked boxes lying around begging you to throw them around—and that's about it.

The sounds lack punch. The voices in-game, especially in the CTF modes, are retarded. Your team-mate keeps yelling in an awkward kind of way like the folks from *300*. The music isn't any better either.

Our machine—a Core 2 Duo E6700, 2 GB of RAM, and a GeForce 8800GTX only managed 30 to 45 fps at 1280 x 1024 with HDR and Motion Blur on. The PPU might have helped elevate the performance a bit, but it's still far from being a well-performing game. Nor is it a good-looking one. Loading stages takes a while as well. Yes, the list goes on.

After playing this game a fair bit and getting excited a couple of times, I realise I've only had my spirits raised and then smashed into the ground. I'm left confused and pondering over the point of all this. And after some soul-searching, I have to say *CellFactor* feels more like a tech demo than a game. It isn't anywhere close to exciting.

If you were planning on buying a physics card just to play *CellFactor*, don't bother. This game's only saving grace is its fairly decent looks and the semi-cool physics effects, and that's the only reason I'm giving it a 5—and maybe because it's free.

rossi_fernandes@
thinkdigit.com

Rating: 5/10, Developer: Artificial Studios, Timeline Interactive, Immersion Games, Publisher: SouthPeak

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XFX GeForce 8800GTX, Intel Core 2 Duo E6700, 2GB RAM, Windows XP Professional, Hitachi 250 GB HDD

